So much of the season had been about doubt and frustration and anger. I took off towards the corner flag at the Stadium of Light and those emotions might just as well have been worries from another lifetime. I couldn't have wanted better: here we were, never mind the doubters, turning in a performance up there with the games in Munich and Sapporo. Sven was buzzing afterwards, handing all the credit to us. When we don't play well, he always seems to be there, ready to take the abuse. When we win, he'll just nod and say to people:

'The players were fantastic tonight. I'm very pleased for them.'

Heading back to Manchester, early Thursday morning, I couldn't help but take all the positive energy of the night before down the highway with me. Could I put the problems between me and Alex Ferguson to one side? Gary Neville always used to say the boss got after every player at least once a season: that was his way. You couldn't argue with the results. He'd always got more out of us, hadn't he, year after year? Maybe things could be different for me between now and the end of the season. We'd made a mess of things in the Worthington Cup Final and lost 2–0 to Liverpool. We were out of the FA Cup too: I wasn't ever going to forget that. But we were still right up there in the Premiership. It was going to come down to us or Arsenal again, I was sure. And in the Champions League, we'd drawn Real Madrid in the quarters. One way or another, nobody ever got bored playing for, or watching, United. I was as desperate as I'd ever been to be involved. The European Cup Final, to be played at Old Trafford, was less than two months away. More history was there to be made.

We were out on the training ground when we found out United would play Madrid. As far as I can see, it's the best game in Europe. Not just because it's between two huge clubs but because of the way the two teams play soccer. We knew from past experience how good the games would be to play in. We knew what the atmosphere would be like as well. Who doesn't get excited, stepping out to play at Old Trafford or the Bernabeu? All of us at United were convinced that, if we could beat Real, we could go on and win the competition. You could feel the buzz everywhere you went around Manchester ahead of those games against Madrid.

I seem to remember that it was right around the time the draw was made —two weeks before the first leg—that stories started appearing in the papers about me being transferred to Real. I knew those rumors had nothing to do with me and didn't imagine they could be anything to do with the club either. I thought the manager was right when he put them down to mischief-making: